domestic factors are in addition to the aforementioned security concerns that accompany any considered action against the group.

How did Lashkar grow so powerful? It began as a small band of men who joined forces with the ambition to unite the Pakistani Ahl-e-Hadith movement and purify society through dawa and jihad. This jihad was not nation-centric, but rather pan-Islamist, and members fought on multiple fronts during the group's early years of operation. Jihad was also obligatory according to Lashkar's interpretation, a view that estranged it from the small Ahl-e-Hadith movement in Pakistan. The group had major ambitions inside the country and abroad, but the nature of those ambitions closed off avenues of support among its primary audience. The offer of state sponsorship to promote the scale and lethality of Lashkar's participation in the Kashmir jihad was a significant opportunity, and the group seized it. Fighting there also aligned with the group's ideological preferences. It was the closest Muslim land under perceived occupation and therefore deemed the most important one for Lashkar. However, the group did not view this simply as territory in need of liberation. The Kashmir jihad was part of a larger battle against Hindus, which its leaders believe has existed since the inception of Islam. Increased focus on and participation in the conflict in Indian-administered Kashmir have reinforced Lashkar's extreme anti-Hindu convictions.

Pakistan's reliance on proxies dates back to the days of Partition. Since then successive governments, civilian and military, have instrumentalized Islam to promote cohesion at home and foreign policy aims abroad. As Husain Haqqani, Pakistan's Ambassador to the US at the time of writing, observed, these policies evolved into a 'strategic commitment to jihadi ideology.'[6] Lashkar is among the most fruitful results of these policies. The army and ISI initially supported the group as a result of its small size and lack of natural allies in Pakistan, the assumption being that Lashkar could become powerful externally without building up a significant support base or threating the state domestically. This assumption proved only partly correct. State support enabled the group to develop a powerful military apparatus, but because of its commitment to dawa, Lashkar also channeled a significant portion of the resources it received into the provision of social services as a means of missionary outreach. Thus, by the late 1990s it controlled a robust social welfare as well as a powerful military apparatus. In addition to its infrastructure in Pakistan, Lashkar wove together